Within a short time, relations between Havana and Washington worsened, while the growing relationship between Havana and Moscow was becoming apparent. None of this should obscure Castro's genuine commitment to improving the lives of Cuba's poor. As the British ambassador to Cuba observed, Castro had 'a genuine passion for the poor and underprivileged … the warmth of affection he professes for the Cuban peasant is almost certainly genuine.'[23] Land reform, public health, and literacy campaigns aimed to transform the lives of the Cuban people. And Castro's commitment to social justice undoubtedly resulted in significant and enduring advances in health care and literacy, especially for those living in rural poverty. The management of the Cuban economy was a different story. From being a leading regional economy before the revolution, economic development reflected the innate problems of a state-planned economy, compounded by the prolonged economic sanctions imposed by Washington.[24]

In February 1960 Anastas Mikoyan, Khrushchev's trusted deputy premier, visited Havana and agreed a trade deal that exchanged Cuban sugar for Soviet oil. Mikoyan was to play a central role in relations between Havana and Moscow (and an important voice of reason in the Kremlin during the missile crisis). When, four months after the trade deal was signed, Esso, Texaco and Shell refused to process Soviet oil, Castro nationalised their Cuban operations. Mikoyan's meetings with Castro also prompted requests for Soviet weapons. The Cubans wanted small arms and ammunition, but also sought aircraft to replace those Batista had purchased from Britain (which Washington successfully blocked). Moscow prevailed on the Czechoslovakian government to act as proxy, and Prague also provided training for Cuban pilots of the MiG-17 [NATO designation Fresco] fighters that began arriving the following year.

In July 1960 President Eisenhower suspended the Cuba sugar quota, effectively reducing Havana's exports to the United States by eighty per cent. Moscow immediately offered to buy the sugar intended for the US market. Soon after, the People's Republic of China (PRC) also committed itself to buying Cuban sugar. In August 1960 Havana responded by nationalising US-owned industrial and agricultural firms, followed by US-